

Pilot Research Project on Cloverbelt Local Food Co-op



What happens when you buy local?

For every dollar you spend...

*Actual Cloverbelt supplier data

- Support your community
- Fresh and delicious food



Stays in
NWO



Stays in
Ontario



Stays in
Canada



Kim Ducharme, HBSW Placement Student, Lakehead University

Connie H. Nelson, Ph.D. HBSW Placement Supervisor
cnelson@lakeheadu.ca

Date Started: May 7, 2020
Date Completed: July 16, 2020
337.5hrs



TABLE OF CONTENTS

Acknowledgements	2
List of Tables	3
List of Figures	4
Introduction	5
Purpose	7
Methodology	8
Findings	12
Discussion	33
References	63
Appendices	64

Acknowledgements

Thank you to all the residents of Northwestern Ontario who volunteered to participate in the Pilot Research Project that provides community perspectives on factors that contributed to the dissolution of CLFC (Cloverbelt Local Food Co-op) and community perspectives on the future of local food production, processing and distribution in Northwestern Ontario. Your participation has provided guidance in identifying strengths, weaknesses, opportunities and threats to the sustainability of CLFC; and what we can learn from these challenges in sustaining local food production, processing and distribution in Northwestern Ontario.

A big thank you to Kim Ducharme who organized and facilitated the Zoom focus groups, who distributed through various social media the on-line surveys, and reached out to participants who participated in follow-up interviews. Kim completed this pilot research project for her 4th Year HBSW field placement. The HBSW Field Coordinator, Jill Zachary was very supportive of this research project as a fourth year field placement.

This research is funded through a national SSHRC Partnership Grant FLEDGE (Food: Locally Embedded, Globally Engaged). In the Fall, the plan is to further explore the dynamics of CLFC Food Co-op through a complex adaptive systems perspective.

LIST OF TABLES

TABLE 1 Participant Composition for the Three Sample Groups: Zoom Focus Groups, On-line Survey and Follow-up Interviews	8
TABLE 2.1 Strengths of CLFC as Described in ZOOM Focus Groups	13
TABLE 2.2 Weaknesses of CLFC as Described in ZOOM Focus Groups	15
TABLE 2.3 Opportunities for the CLFC as Described in ZOOM Focus Groups	16
TABLE 2.4 Threats to the CLFC as Described in ZOOM Focus Groups	19
TABLE 3.1 Strengths of CLFC as Described in On-line Survey	21
TABLE 3.2 Weaknesses of CLFC as Described in On-line Survey	22
TABLE 3.3 Opportunities for the CLFC as Described in On-line Survey	23
TABLE 3.4 Threats to the CLFC as Described in On-line Survey	26
TABLE 4.1 Strengths of CLFC as Described in Interviews	27
TABLE 4.1 Weaknesses of CLFC as Described in Interviews	28
TABLE 4.1 Opportunities for the CLFC as Described in Interviews	29
TABLE 4.1 Threats to the CLFC as Described in Interviews	32
TABLE 5. Survey Responses for Importance of Local Food Sources	34

LIST OF FIGURES

Figure 1. Location of CLFC Distribution Hubs	5
--	---

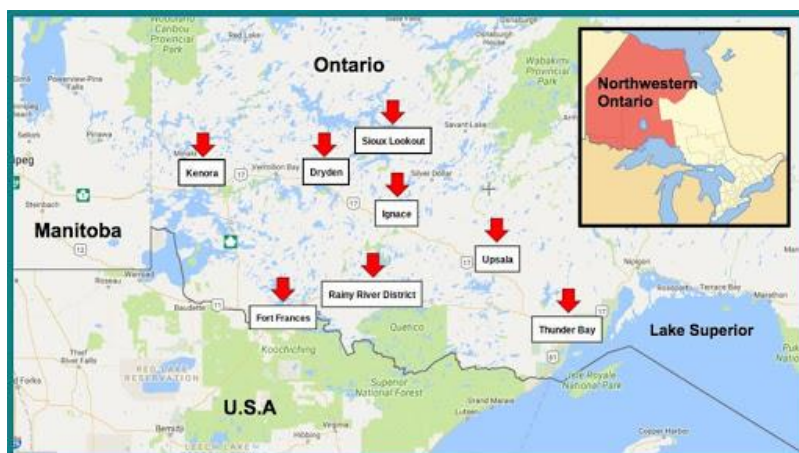
INTRODUCTION

(Adapted from Nelson et al., 2019 and <http://nourishingontario.ca/the-cloverbelt-local-food-co-op/>)

Cloverbelt Local Food Co-op (CLFC) emerged from a desire among farmers in the Dryden area to be better connected. Dryden, being the geopolitical centre of Northwestern Ontario (NWO) is considered the primary asset in the production and distribution of local food throughout NWO. Before CLFC was founded, there was a concern that the agricultural

community was becoming smaller, disjointed, and did not

Figure 1: Location of CLFC Distribution Hubs



attract new producers. For the few remaining farmers in the area, there were not many opportunities to come together as a community to sell their products.

Overall options were limited to seasonal markets that required producers to spend ten or more hours each week traveling to these widely-scattered markets rather than spending this time on farm production. They could sell at the Cloverbelt Farmers' Market, which operated in Dryden and the nearby township of Oxdrift, Sioux Lookout, Vermillion Bay and Kenora, but these markets only ran during the summer and early fall months when fresh produce is abundant. Another option for farmers to sell local was the LocaVore Box program. Consumers can pay an up-front fee to receive a box of in-season local food items every two weeks, but it was difficult for some farms to regularly supply the exact number of products expected of them, especially the

Pilot Research Project on Cloverbelt Local Food Co-op

small farms that did not have the capacity to offer items in bulk. Moreover, it was difficult for small farms to compete with larger ones in other parts of the province, which often have much more capital to cover the costs of shipping, packaging, and other operations required for their products to meet regulatory standards.

CLFC grew rapidly since its beginning in 2013. What started with just 85 members in the Dryden community grew to a membership of over 1,200 in more than five communities across NWO, with expansion to more communities expected. All products were sold through the co-op's website, which operated year-round and was open to anyone in NWO interested in buying or selling locally-grown foods and other goods. The CLFC allowed local consumers to connect with local farmers from the comfort of their own homes, as the first on-line food co-op in Ontario. (See video link celebrating the CLFC <https://vimeo.com/313895388>).

Prior to the formation of CLFC, access to local food occurred mostly incidentally through direct contact initiated through consumers, or through seasonal events such as farmer markets or basket shares. Along with significantly expanding its membership base within four years, CLFC had accomplished major projects such as a community greenhouse and an online interactive map showing the location of local producers throughout NWO (discussed below), both of which supported the co-op's overall goal of building up local food within the region and connecting producers. See an example of the CLFC newsletter that went out to members on a regular basis <https://mailchi.mp/712e46af734b/make-a-wild-rice-mushroom-and-sausage-frittata-we-have-cherry-tomatoes-and-more?e=8491b80783>.

When word that this once successful food co-op was now struggling to continue, the community response was one of surprise and disappointment. (See newsletter link here; <https://us3.campaign-archive.com/?u=2d0f9095d7bef7aa7117b23ec&id=0a06a3f915>). On September 10, 2019, the Co-op held a Special Membership Meeting at the Dryden District Agricultural Centre, with online access for members throughout the region. This community gathering, and final member meeting was posted on the Cloverbelt website (See Appendix A for the final letter to CLFC members).

Following this introduction, this report reviews the purpose and the methodology used in obtaining the project data. We then present our analysis, interspersed with selected illustrative quotes. We conclude with a summary of the community interpretations of their experiences.

PURPOSE OF PILOT RESEARCH PROJECT

This pilot research project aims to provide opportunities for community members (1) to identify tipping points such as policies and regulations (local, provincial and federal) that raised challenges for the viability of CLFC Local Food Co-op; (2) to raise awareness of different advocacy approaches to modifying policies and regulations (local, provincial and federal) that would support new infrastructure in the region for enhancing production, processing, distributing and consuming local regional foods; (3) to identify opportunities for the re-emergence of viable local food production, processing, and distribution in Northwestern Ontario.

This pilot research project through a complexity science approach included an examination of data from three sample groups – participants in the Zoom meetings, an on-line survey and follow up interviews.

METHODOLOGY

This pilot research project was developed as a placement opportunity and had originally included travel to the various communities for in-person focus groups and interviews. With the onset of Covid-19 restrictions and limitations, it was necessary to approach this project through various on-line processes. Funded through a SSHRC Partnership Grant FLEDGE (Food: Locally Embedded, Globally Engaged), the research focused on the community perspectives on factors that contributed to the dissolution of CLFC and community perspectives on the future of local food production, processing and distribution in Northwestern Ontario (NWO).

This paper reports findings from the various communities in NWO where CLFC operated, aimed at establishing an understanding of the complexity associated with the dissolution. This includes community members from Dryden, Kenora, Sioux Lookout, Rainy River, Ignace and Upsala who wish to share their experiential knowledge as producers, processors and/or consumers of how CLFC Food Co-op impacted their involvement with local foods.

Sample

Table 1. Participant Composition for the Three Sample Groups: Zoom Focus Groups, On-line Survey and Follow-up Interviews

	Zoom Focus Groups	On-line Survey	Follow-up Interview	Total
Board Member	0	0	1	1
Consumer Member	13	15	2	30
Producer Member	1	4	0	5
Member (non-specific)	0	4	0	4
Former employee	2	1	1	4
Closed before could join	3	1	1	5
Non-Member	5	9	2	16
TOTAL	24	34	7	65

Complexity Science Approach

This research uses a complex adaptive systems (CAS) framework to explore the tipping points for the dissolution of CLFC in 2019 and to discover opportunities for the re-emergence of viable local food production, processing and distribution across Northwestern Ontario.

This research seeks to meet the following objectives following the announcement of the dissolution of the CLFC (see Appendix A – CLFC Dissolution Post):

1. to explore the tipping points in the operation of CLFC (2013-2019) that contributed to the decision by the co-op members to dissolve CLFC. [Possible tipping points include technical challenges such as distribution among the community food hubs, engagement of food hubs, and on-line system; staffing (number and spread across 9 service areas over a large geographic area with sparse population; external policies and regulations; permitting; and financial challenges.
2. To assess opportunities for the re-emergence of viable food production, processing and distribution across Northwestern Ontario.

Research Design

The aim of this research was to identify learnings that could benefit those most impacted by the gap in access to the local food market that the dissolution of CLFC leaves behind. Inviting CLFC members and the general public of NWO to focus on key survey questions through Zoom focus groups, online survey and follow-up interviews from both the Zoom meetings and the on-line surveys. , with the intention of sharing research findings for the purpose of stimulating newfound ways of restoring capital and energy in the local food system. The following questions

Pilot Research Project on Cloverbelt Local Food Co-op

framed the Zoom focus group meetings, the on-line surveys and follow-up interviews. through the

Research Questions

1. How important is access to local food sources to you and your family?
 - Very important
 - Moderately important
 - Not so much.
 - I'm not as familiar with local food sources as I would like to be.
2. Tell us about your relationship with CLOVERBELT LOCAL FOOD CO-OP.
3. What do you miss most about CLOVERBELT LOCAL FOOD CO-OP?
4. From your experience, what was the biggest barrier to regularly using CLOVERBELT LOCAL FOOD CO-OP?
5. From your experience, what were the strengths of the CLOVERBELT LOCAL FOOD CO-OP?
6. If you could have suggested an improvement to CLOVERBELT LOCAL FOOD CO-OP, what would it be?
7. If you could re-imagine a NEW local food co-op, what would it look like?
8. Do you have any other comments or helpful information to share?
9. We want to hear from you. If you are interested in discussing further, please provide your contact information below.

This research was applied, descriptive and relied on a combination of two of the classic social sciences research tools – questionnaires and interviews. The proposed research was

developed from a qualitative point of view. Consent forms were provided to all participants (see Appendix D – Participant Consent Form). The following three sample methods included;

1. On-line survey (see Appendix B – Survey Post & Invite) was created and promoted via email networks and social media. Thirty-four surveys were completed between May 14/2020 to June 3/2020).
2. Focus Group via Facebook Event Page “Cloverbelt Local Food Co-op; Where do we go from here?” (see Appendix C – Zoom Focus Group Invite) was created and promoted seven ZOOM focus groups open to the public;
 - a. Red Lake ZOOM Focus Group- Time: May 25, 2020 10:00 AM Eastern Time - Zero participants attended.
 - b. Dryden ZOOM Focus Group - Time: May 25, 2020 02:00 PM Eastern Time - Five participants attended.
 - c. Sioux Lookout ZOOM Focus Group - Time: May 26, 2020 10:00 AM Eastern Time- Three participants attended.
 - d. Fort Frances/Emo/Rainy River ZOOM Focus Group - Time: May 26, 2020 2:00 AM Eastern Time - Two participants attended.
 - e. Kenora ZOOM Focus Group – Time: May 27, 2020 10:00 AM Eastern Time - Seven participants attended.
 - f. Ignace/Upsula ZOOM Focus Group – Time: May 27, 2020 02:00 PM Eastern Time- Three participants attended.
 - g. Open/Non-Specific ZOOM Focus Group – Time: May 27, 2020 06:00 PM Eastern Time - Three participants attended.

3. Individual interviews – Seventeen survey participants provided their contact information within the survey and were then invited by email to connect for further discussion. Six participants responded and were individually interviewed as follow up to their survey responses. Interviews were held between June 23 – 30th.

FINDINGS

Emerging themes suggest the importance of the CLFC as a viable local food production, processing and distribution program for NWO, and the challenges that come with such an interconnected, complex system. Moreover, opportunities for adaptation supporting the re-emergence of the CLFC appeared throughout the three sample groups.

The findings from the Zoom focus groups were recorded and used to construct a set of four tables: Strengths, Weaknesses, Opportunities and Threats. Each table contains ideas from the participants by category. Each table identified the location of the Zoom Hub Participants and the number of participants from all hubs who mentioned each of the categories under Strengths, Weaknesses, Opportunities and Threats. These same categories were used to construct four tables (Strengths, Weaknesses, Opportunities and Threats) that summarize the ideas from all participants that filled out the on-line survey. Similarly, these same categories were used to construct four tables (Strengths, Weaknesses, Opportunities and Threats) that summarize the ideas from all follow-up interview participants.

TABLE 2.1 Strengths of CLFC as Described in ZOOM Focus Groups

STRENGTHS	Total Partic ipants 24	RED LAKE (0)	DRY DEN (5)	SIOUX LOOK OUT (3)	FF/ EMO /RR (3)	KENOR A (7)	IGNAC E /UPSU LA (3)	OPEN/ NON- SPECIFIC (3)
1.Local food source/security	10		✓✓✓ ✓	✓		✓✓	✓	✓✓
2.Healthy/quality food	5		✓✓	✓✓✓				
3.Variety	7			✓✓✓		✓✓	✓	✓
4.Community-based	4		✓	✓		✓		✓
5.Convenience of online ordering	9		✓✓✓ ✓	✓		✓✓		✓✓
6.Alternative to attending a busy farmer's market	3		✓✓			✓		
7.Supports local economy	6		✓✓✓	✓		✓	✓	
8.Refrigerated shed	2		✓					✓
9.Cloverbelt greenhouse/garden bed rentals	2		✓					✓
10.Year-round access to vendors	4		✓			✓		✓✓
11.School-based collaborations & programming	3		✓			✓		✓
12.Connecting the consumer with the producers (relationships)	11		✓✓	✓✓		✓✓✓	✓	✓✓✓
13.Centralized/efficient process for accessing local food	8		✓	✓✓	✓		✓✓	✓✓
14.One payment process for multiple producers	4		✓		✓			✓✓
15.Community collaboration -	3		✓	✓	✓			

Pilot Research Project on Cloverbelt Local Food Co-op

Donated resources (ie refrigerated trucks)								
16.Value hand- made/produced	2			✓		✓		
17.Newsletter	3					✓✓✓		
18.Provides beyond local – serves Region	2		✓			✓		
19.Hub Week	2					✓✓		
20.Website	3				✓			✓✓
21.Paid Coordinator for each hub site (when it was in place)	2		✓			✓		
22.Producer forums	1							✓
23.Price Points	2					✓		✓
24.Dedicated volunteers & producers	0							
25.Reliability	1							✓
26.Friendly, welcoming group	1			✓				
27.Organized & consistent	1							✓
28.Love Local Boxes	3		✓			✓✓		

TABLE 2.2 Weaknesses of CLFC as Described in ZOOM Focus Groups

WEAKNESSES	Total	RED LAKE (0)	DRYDEN (5)	SIOUX LOOK OUT (3)	FF/ EMO /RR (3)	KENORA (7)	IGNACE /UPSULA (3)	OPEN/NON- SPECIFIC (3)
1.Transportation & Delivery	7		✓✓	✓✓	✓	✓	✓	
2.No online payment process	0							
3.Website	6		✓✓	✓	✓	✓		✓
4.Lack of Coordination	3			✓		✓		✓
5.Business Model & operations (reliant on grants & volunteers)	11		✓✓✓✓	✓✓✓		✓✓		✓✓
6.Inconsistencies in staffing	6		✓	✓		✓✓		✓✓
7.Lack of Cornerstone Product (eggs, meat)	6		✓	✓		✓✓		✓✓
8.Pick up Processes	6		✓	✓✓	✓	✓	✓	
9.Communication and clarity for membership	4		✓			✓		✓✓
10.Bookkeeping	2							✓✓
11.Competency issues - Board	3		✓	✓				✓
12.IT Competency issues - farmers	2		✓			✓		
13.Inconsistency of product availability	3					✓		✓✓
14.Quality control	5				✓	✓✓		✓✓
15.Gov't Regs	7		✓✓✓	✓		✓		✓✓
16.Other Options Evolved	1							✓

17. Marketing & awareness	2		✓			✓		
18. Membership regulations	2					✓		✓
19. Producer membership requirements	4					✓		✓✓✓
20. Producer membership policies & procedures missing								
21. Lack of variety								
22. Unsustainable								

TABLE 2.3 Opportunities for the CLFC as Described in ZOOM Focus Groups

OPPOR-TUNITIES	Total	RED LAKE (0)	DRY DEN (5)	SIOUX LOOK OUT (3)	FF/ EMO /RR (3)	KEN ORA (7)	IGNACE /UPSULA (3)	OPEN /NON-SPECIFIC (3)
1. New Board interest	1							✓
2. Self-sufficiency in tough times (ie COVID)	1		✓					
3. Farmers Market Ontario collaboration	3		✓		✓			✓
4. Advancements in technology for online ordering	3		✓		✓			✓
5. Good Food Box	1						✓	
6. Cloverbelt Farmers Market	2		✓✓					
7. Harvest Kenora	2					✓✓		
8. Lake of the Woods Brewing Company	2			✓		✓		

Pilot Research Project on Cloverbelt Local Food Co-op

9.Broken Paddle Coffee Roastery & Kitchen	1					✓		
10.Pars Jars/GROWcery Service	4		✓	✓	✓	✓		
11.Cash & Carry Mart	2			✓✓				
12.Northwest Beef	2			✓✓				
13.Metowski Market	3					✓✓✓		
14.Women's Place (Kenora)	1					✓		
15.Seasons' Website (Tbay)	2		✓			✓		
16.Thunder Bay Market	4		✓✓			✓✓		
17.Healthy Living Food Box (FF)	1						✓	
18.CSA	4		✓	✓✓✓				
19.Hydroponics	3			✓✓		✓		
20.City of Dryden Agriculture Society	1							✓
21.City of Dryden	1							✓
22.Open Food Network Food Service, Online	2		✓					✓
23.Local school boards	1					✓		
24.High school student volunteers	3		✓	✓		✓		
25.Manitoba producers	0							
26.First Nations Communities	5		✓✓	✓✓		✓		
27.SLAAM (Sioux Lookout Aboriginal Area Management Board	1			✓				

Pilot Research Project on Cloverbelt Local Food Co-op

28.Fireweed Coop (Wpg)	0							
29.Delivery service	5		✓✓	✓✓✓				
30.Vendors are more tech savvy	1		✓					
31.Community impact chain reaction	3		✓	✓	✓			
32.Integrating into existing storefronts/restaurants	5		✓✓	✓✓	✓			
33.Member agreements/contracts ie. commit to volunteer hours	3			✓✓		✓		
34.Employment – FT consistent position	4		✓	✓		✓		✓
35.Streamlined distribution service	3		✓	✓	✓			
36.Commercial kitchens	2				✓✓			
37.Marketing & social media	1					✓		
38.Public Education/programming	4		✓	✓		✓		✓
39.Online app for ordering	2					✓		✓
40.Recrut major partner as consumer	2					✓✓		
41.Standardized basic box or subscription box	4			✓		✓✓	✓	
42.Local food information source	1						✓	
43.Online process created upselling opps	2							✓✓
44.Fresh new Board	1							✓

45.Reduce plastic bags	0							
46.Impact of COVID & Advocacy	5		✓✓ ✓	✓		✓		
47.Funding opps (Northern Harvesters Program, Sioux Lookout First Nations Health Authority, Greenbelt Grants, School Grants, SNAPP grants)	4			✓	✓	✓✓		
48.More greenhouse growers								

TABLE 2.4 Threats to the CLFC as Described in ZOOM Focus Groups

THREATS	Total	RED LAKE (0)	DRY DEN (5)	SIOUX LOOK OUT (3)	FF/ EMO /RR (3)	KENOR A (7)	IGNACE/ UPSULA (3)	OPEN/ NON-SPECIFIC (3)
1.Upselling outside of system	1			✓				
2.Distance between communities	2			✓			✓	
3.Inconsistencies in staff	3			✓		✓		✓
4.Lack of collaboration & advocacy								
5.Not enough product	4			✓	✓	✓		✓
6.Competency of Board & Staff	4		✓	✓		✓		✓
7.Gov't Regs	10		✓✓✓	✓✓✓	✓	✓		✓✓
8.Winter Roads & Logistics	5		✓✓	✓✓		✓		

9.Lack of quality control	2			✓	✓			
10.Producers/farmers are busy producing, don't have time to deal with delivery	1				✓			
11.Producers/farmers retire/become ill/shut down for upgrades	4		✓✓			✓		✓
12.One farmer's closure creates domino effect on the others who collaborate with them	5		✓	✓✓				✓✓
13.Affordability	3					✓✓	✓	
14.Lack of funding sources	5		✓✓	✓		✓		✓
15.Consumers moving towards growing their own food	2			✓				✓
16.Customers forgetting times to order/pick up	3		✓	✓		✓		
17.Bigger is not always better	0							
18.Reliance on Volunteers	8		✓✓	✓✓		✓✓		✓✓
19.Export demands & grocery chains absorbing the market	1			✓				
20.On-line processes are everywhere now	4				✓✓✓			✓
21.Trust lost as a result of the dissolution	3				✓			✓✓

22.Lack of education on how to prepare local/seasonal foods								
23.Government reps not engaged with community/facilitating development								

TABLE 3.1 Strengths of CLFC as Described in On-line Survey

STRENGTHS	Total /34	SURVEY
1.Local food source/security	22	✓✓✓✓✓✓✓✓✓✓✓✓ ✓✓✓✓✓✓✓✓✓✓
2.Healthy/quality food	3	✓✓✓
3.Variety	7	✓✓✓✓✓✓✓
4.Community-based	3	✓✓✓
5.Convenience of online ordering	8	✓✓✓✓✓✓✓✓
6.Alternative to attending a busy farmer's market	2	✓✓
7.Supports local economy	1	✓
8.Refrigerated shed	0	
9.Cloverbelt greenhouse/garden bed rentals	1	✓
10.Year-round access to vendors	5	✓✓✓✓✓
11.School-based collaborations & programming	1	✓
12.Connecting the consumer with the producers (relationships)	5	✓✓✓✓✓
13.Centralized/efficient process for accessing local food	8	✓✓✓✓✓✓✓✓
14.One payment process for multiple producers	0	

15.Community collaboration - Donated resources (ie refrigerated trucks)	1	✓
16.Value hand-made/produced	1	✓
17.Newsletter	0	
18.Provides beyond local – serves Region		
19.Hub Week	0	
20.Website	2	✓✓
21.Paid Coordinator for each hub site (when it was in place)	0	
22.Producer forums	0	
23.Price Points	3	✓✓✓
24.Dedicated volunteers & producers	1	✓
25.Reliability	1	✓
26.Friendly, welcoming group	3	✓✓✓
27.Organized & consistent	0	
28.Love Local Boxes	0	

TABLE 3.2 Weaknesses of CLFC as Described in On-line Survey

WEAKNESSES	TOTAL /34	SURVEY
1.Transportation & Delivery	6	✓✓✓✓✓✓
2.No online payment process	1	✓
3.Website	3	✓✓✓
4.Lack of Coordination	0	
5.Business Model & operations (reliant on grant monies & volunteers)	3	✓✓✓
6.Inconsistencies in staffing	1	✓

7.Lack of Cornerstone Product (eggs, meat)	1	✓
8.Pick up Processes	8	✓✓✓✓✓✓✓✓
9.Communication and clarity for membership	0	
10.Bookkeeping	0	
11.Competency issues – Board	1	✓
12.IT Competency issues - farmers		
13.Inconsistency of product availability		
14.Quality control	1	✓
15.Gov't Regs		
16.Other Options Evolved	1	✓
17.Marketing & awareness	2	✓✓
18.Membership regulations	1	✓
19.Producer membership requirements		
20.Producer membership policies & procedures missing		
21.Lack of variety	1	✓
22.Unsustainable	1	✓

TABLE 3.3 Opportunities for CLFC as Described in On-line Survey

OPPORTUNITIES	Total /34	SURVEY
1.New Board interest		
2.Self-sufficiency in tough times (ie COVID)		
3.Farmers Market Ontario collaboration		
4.Advancements in technology for online ordering	1	✓
5.Good Food Box		

6.Cloverbelt Farmers Market	1	✓
7.Harvest Kenora		
8.Lake of the Woods Brewing Company		
9.Broken Paddle Coffee Roastery & Kitchen		
10.Pars Jars/GROWcery Services	1	
11.Cash & Carry Mart		
12.Northwest Beef		
13.Metowski Market	1	✓
14.Women's Place (Kenora)		
15.Seasons' Website (Tbay)		
16.Thunder Bay Market		
17.Healthy Living Food Box (FF)		
18.CSA		
19.Hydroponics		
20.City of Dryden Agriculture Society		
21.City of Dryden		
22.Open Food Network Food Service, Online	1	✓
23.Local school boards		
24.High school student volunteers		
25.Manitoba producers	1	✓
26.First Nations Communities	1	✓
27.SLAAM (Sioux Lookout Aboriginal Area Management Board)		
28.Fireweed Coop (Wpg)	1	✓
29.Delivery service	5	✓✓✓✓✓

30.Vendors are more tech savvy	0	
31.Community impact chain reaction	1	✓
32.Integrating into existing storefronts	3	✓✓✓
33.Member agreements/contracts ie. commit to volunteer hours	2	✓✓
34.Employment – FT consistent position	1	✓
35.Streamlined distribution service	3	✓✓✓
36.Commercial kitchens	1	✓
37.Marketing & social media	2	✓✓
38.Public Education/programming	0	
39.Online app for ordering	3	✓✓✓
40.Recruit major partner as consumer	1	✓
41.Standardized basic box or subscription box	1	✓
42.Local food information source	1	✓
43.Online store created upselling opps		
44.Fresh new Board		
45.Reduce plastic bags	1	✓
46.Impact of COVID & Advocacy		
47.Funding opps (Northern Harvesters Program, Sioux Lookout First Nations Health Authority, Greenbelt Grants, School Grants, SNAPP grants)		
48.More greenhouse growers		

TABLE 3.4 Threats to CLFC as Described in On-line Survey

THREATS	TOTAL/34	SURVEY
1.Upselling outside of system		
2.Distance between communities	1	✓
3.Inconsistencies in staff		
4.Lack of collaboration & advocacy		
5.Not enough product	1	✓
6.Competency of Board & staff		
7.Gov't Regs		
8.Winter Roads & Logistics		
9.Lack of quality control	1	✓
10.Producers/farmers are busy producing, don't have time to deal with delivery		
11.Producers/farmers retire/become ill/shut down for upgrades		
12.One farmer's closure creates domino effect on the others who collaborate with them		
13.Affordability	5	✓✓✓✓✓
14.Lack of Funding sources		
15.Consumers moving towards growing their own food		
16.Customers forgetting times to order/pick up	2	✓✓
17.Bigger is not always better	1	✓
18.Reliance on volunteers		
19.Export demands & grocery chains absorbing the market		
20.On-line processes are everywhere now		
21.Trust lost as a result of dissolution		

22.Lack of education on how to prepare local/seasonal foods		
23.Government reps not engaged with community/facilitating development		

TABLE 4.1 Strengths of CLFC as Described in Individual Interviews

STRENGTHS		J.	M.	Z.	B.	J.	P./K.
1.Local food source/security	6	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
2.Healthy/quality food	4	✓			✓	✓	✓
3.Variety							
4.Community-based	1		✓				
5.Convenience of online ordering	3	✓		✓		✓	
6.Alternative to attending a busy farmer's market	3		✓	✓		✓	
7.Supports local economy	1					✓	
8.Refrigerated shed							
9.Cloverbelt greenhouse/garden bed rentals							
10.Year-round access to vendors	1				✓		
11.School-based collaborations & programming							
12.Connecting the consumer with the producers (relationships)	1			✓			
13.Centralized/efficient process for accessing local food	3		✓	✓	✓		
14.One payment process for multiple producers							
15.Community collaboration - Donated resources (ie refrigerated trucks)							
16.Value hand-made/produced							
17.Newsletter	1					✓	
18.Provides beyond local – serves Region	2			✓	✓		
19.Hub Week							

20.Website	1	✓					
21.Paid Coordinator for each hub site (when it was in place)							
22.Producer forums							
23.Price Points							
24.Dedicated volunteers & producers	1				✓		
25.Reliability	1	✓					
26.Friendly, welcoming group							
27.Organized & consistent							
28.Love Local Boxes							

TABLE 4.2 Weaknesses of CLFC as Described in Individual Interviews

WEAKNESSES		J.	M.	Z.	B.	J.	P./K.
1.Transportation & Delivery	3		✓		✓		✓
2.No online payment process							
3.Website	2		✓		✓		
4.Lack of Coordination	1						✓
5.Business Model & operations (reliant on grant monies & volunteers)	3		✓		✓		✓
6.Inconsistencies in staffing							
7.Lack of Cornerstone Product (eggs, meat)							
8.Pick up Processes	2		✓			✓	
9.Communication and clarity for membership							

10.Bookkeeping	1		✓				
11.Competency issues – Board	1		✓				
12.IT Competency issues - farmers	2				✓		✓
13.Inconsistency of product availability	1		✓				
14.Quality control							
15.Gov't Regs	3		✓		✓		✓
16.Other Options Evolved	1					✓	
17.Marketing & awareness	2		✓				✓
18.Membership regulations							
19.Producer membership requirements							
20.Producer membership policies & procedures missing							
21.Lack of variety	1		✓				
22.Unsustainable	1						✓

TABLE 4.3 Opportunities for the CLFC as Described in Individual Interviews

OPPORTUNITIES		J.	M.	Z.	B.	J.	P./K.
1.New Board interest							
2.Self-sufficiency in tough times (ie COVID)	1	✓					
3.Farmers Market Ontario collaboration							
4.Advancements in technology for online ordering							
5.Good Food Box							
6.Cloverbelt Farmers Market	3		✓		✓	✓	
7.Harvest Kenora	1	✓					

8.Lake of the Woods Brewing Company							
9.Broken Paddle Coffee Roastery & Kitchen							
10.Pars Jars/GROWcery Service							
11.Cash & Carry Mart							
12.Northwest Beef							
13.Metowski Market	1		✓				
14.Women's Place (Kenora)							
15.Seasons' Website (Tbay)							
16.Thunder Bay Market							
17.Healthy Living Food Box (FF)	1						✓
18.CSA	3		✓			✓	✓
19.Hydroponics	1			✓			
20.City of Dryden Agriculture Society	1		✓				
21.City of Dryden							
22.Open Food Network Food Service, Online	3			✓	✓		✓
23.Local school boards	1						✓
24.High school student volunteers							
25.Manitoba producers	3		✓		✓		✓
26.First Nations Communities	2				✓		✓
27.SLAAM (Sioux Lookout Aboriginal Area Management Board)							
28.Fireweed Coop (Wpg)							
29.Delivery service	3		✓	✓			✓

30.Vendors are more tech savvy							
31.Community impact chain reaction							
32.Integrating into existing storefronts	1						✓
33.Member agreements/contracts ie. commit to volunteer hours							
34.Employment – FT consistent position							
35.Streamlined distribution service	1		✓				
36.Commercial kitchens							
37.Marketing & social media	2			✓			✓
38.Public Education/programming	1						✓
39.Online app for ordering							
40.Recruit major partner as consumer							
41.Standardized basic box or subscription box	3		✓			✓	✓
42.Local food information source	2					✓	✓
43.Online store created upselling opps							
44.Fresh new Board	1		✓				
45.Reduce plastic bags							
46.Impact of COVID & Advocacy	2			✓			✓
47.Funding opps (Northern Harvesters Program, Sioux Lookout First Nations Health Authority, Greenbelt Grants, School Grants, SNAPP grants)	2				✓		✓
48.More greenhouse growers	1				✓		

TABLE 4.4 Threats to the CLFC as Described in Individual Interviews

THREATS		J.	M.	Z.	B.	J.	P./K.
1.Upselling outside of system							
2.Distance between communities	4		✓		✓	✓	✓
3.Inconsistencies in staff							
4.Lack of collaboration & advocacy	2				✓		✓
5.Not enough product	3		✓		✓		✓
6.Competency of Board & Staff	2		✓				✓
7.Gov't Regs	3		✓		✓		✓
8.Winter Roads & Logistics							
9.Lack of quality control							
10.Producers/farmers are busy producing, don't have time to deal with delivery	2		✓	✓			
11.Producers/farmers retire/become ill/shut down for upgrades	1						✓
12.One farmer's closure creates domino effect on the others who collaborate with them	1						✓
13.Affordability	1						✓
14.Lack of Funding sources							
15.Consumers moving towards growing their own food							
16.Customers forgetting times to order/pick up	1		✓				
17.Bigger is not always better	4		✓		✓	✓	✓
18.Reliance on Volunteers	2		✓			✓	
19.Export demands & grocery chains absorbing the market	1						✓
20.On-line processes are everywhere now							

21.Trust lost as a result of the dissolution							
22.Lack of education on how to prepare local/seasonal foods	1						✓
23.Government reps not engaged with community/facilitating development	1						✓

DISCUSSION OF THE DATA FINDINGS

This pilot research project set out to engage the people of Northwestern Ontario (NWO) to examine the activities leading up to the dissolution of the Cloverbelt Local Food Co-op (CLFC) in anticipation of identifying possible tipping points that raise challenges for the viability of the CLFC as well as to raise awareness around potential advocacy needs to address policies and regulation issues, and identifying the prospects of new opportunities for the re-emergence of the CLFC. In keeping with a complex adaptive systems approach, where an understanding of the individual parts does not automatically convey an understanding of the system as a whole, we are reminded to consider the CLFC as more complicated and meaningful than the aggregate of its parts. The CLFC, as a complex system, has a multitude of individual components and agents – producers, processors, and consumers - that are highly connected and interdependent. Because of this interconnectivity, complex adaptive systems thinking challenges simple cause and effect assumptions, motivating the increased use of system-based approaches to help identify and solve problems and make decisions.

Access to Local Food is Important

A consistent and ongoing theme presented throughout the three data samples was that **access to local food is important**. The survey sample provided the most direct data with regards to the level of

importance of local food. These attitudes remained consistent in the Zoom Focus Groups and interviews, however not as specific.

Table 5. Survey Responses for Importance of Local Food Sources

How important is access to local food sources to you and your family?	NUMBER OF RESPONSES
Very important.	28 (82.35%)
Moderately important.	5 (14.71%)
Not so much.	0 (0.00%)
I'm not as familiar with local food sources as I would like to be.	1 (2.94%)
TOTAL	34

One of the Zoom Focus Group participants indicated the following; “....*given everything that is going on with meat produce, you know, mass produced meat and everything and this pandemic, we really should be striving to have locally sourced, locally produced, ummm, meats, and I think that we have an abattoir now, that is larger and bigger, and is able, I know that there is meat coming from east of Thunder Bay for this new abattoir and is locally being produced. Keeping things local, keeping things in employed, keeping farmers, small farmers, I think it’s really important that we support them*”

Another Zoom Focus Group participant had this to say; “*My relationship with Cloverbelt is, I was a consumer from the get go.... really sad to see it go.... Me and my husband don’t like to support factory farms and we don’t buy our meat from the store. not having the access to the great preserves and all the stuff that our producers made, easy, I got used to, right?it was around in Dryden for I think, for over 5 years, that is where I got all my pickles, that’s where I got all my jams, that’s where I got everything, really, so it definitely left a big hole in our grocery service*

In a one to one interview, we heard this; “*People are starting to appreciate more local stuff and availability.*”

Further examination of the three samples suggested opinions that the CLFC provided consumers with the advantage of accessing local food from the convenience of their own home, in one centralized location, creating greater **consumer ease** for year-round access.

“My favourite is the CFSA / produce program side of things. Maybe simplifying things by starting with just that. It would make ordering easier, and sorting items at the pickup easier.”

“A lot of the produce we bought in the summer was more from like, the Market, the physical Market, but we did order some through the Co-op, we definitely ordered through the winter, a lot of the local meats. And a lot of those are hard to access without the Co-op, especially the ones from Rainy River and there were a lot of things you could get easily.”

Attitudes relating to consumer ease included complimentary commentaries on the variety of goods and food available, the alternative to physically attending a Farmers Market and the ease to which consumers could support the local food economy versus the current dominant global food system. Additionally, responses noted that a local food economy reduces dependence on fossil fuels, reduces air pollution, and cuts back on greenhouse gas emissions. All of which are good for the environment.

“....this way I was able to buy certain cuts.....it was like a pandemic when we heard they were closing (Cloverbelt) we kind of stocked up” “I miss the fresh vegetables and produce and of course baking that was available...I just like to know where the food comes from, I hate to see something that’s picked how many months, weeks ago, then transported using fossil fuel to get here”.

There was a desire to have greater connections rather than competition among farmers in the NWO region, so building connections within and between communities is a huge part of the CFLC mandate (Nelson et al., 2019).

“I had rented greenhouse plots. So, I used those two plots almost exclusively for growing things that I sold. It was great for me, I really enjoyed it. I’m really missing not having those plots this year. I have a small home greenhouse in my yard, it’s just, it’s not the same. I really loved that big commercial green house, that was fantastic.”

“I know in Kenora, I got very close with, a lot of the people that were constant, that are members, that were always ordering, and stuff like that, most of them were in my

phone, I would see them out in the public and we would chat about stuff....and I do miss those relationships and I think it does bring people together...that was the best part of it for me."

As any system begins to mature, there is an accompanying increase in fixed and ordered patterns of interactions and resource flows. The system becomes over-connected, or better, the existing qualities and quantities of connections are such that they inhibit the formation of new pathways needed for the system's overall adaptation to outside changes and its continued evolution. Eventually this leads to rigidity within the system, and it becomes brittle, less resilient, and more susceptible to disturbances from the outside.

Tipping Points

As a non-profit co-operative, CLFC was owned by all its members. Annual General Meetings where members gave their input on the co-op's activities, and where decisions were made through member voting, were expected. In order to maintain long-term sustainability, consumer memberships included an expectation to place an order at least twice every year and producer members were expected to have products for sale at least once every year. As long as producers continued to sell their products and consumers continued to buy them, the CLFC was expected to grow and prosper.

Tipping Point #1 – Online Service Delivery

The CLFC, appeared well ahead of its time when, in 2013 they launched the online system for local food distribution. All products were sold through the co-op's website (www.cloverbeltlocalfoodcoop.com), that utilized an open-source software program to list and sell products. This software was developed and shared by a member of the Nebraska Food Co-op in the

United States and was open-source software that was used by a number of other co-ops across North America. Enter the first would-be tipping point.

While many of the participants valued the convenience of online access to local food, the website programs adopted by the CLFC appeared to have its challenges, despite several modifications and an upgrade.

“In general, I really liked the co-op, I thought the website, was, you know, it was a little glitchy sometimes but it, ahh, in general, I liked the layout, I liked that you could go to previously ordered items”.

“The first thing you need is ummm, basically, a program. And she was able to find a program in the United States, a guy had done for handling producer consumer food kind of ordering, and we replicated that...here with some help from some local people. So, we used that program. That put us ahead of all of Ontario. Now this is just my opinion, but that put us ahead of all of Ontario and Ontario doesn't allow remote areas like us to be ahead of them, in any way, they kick our asses, you cannot believe how much...they've done their best to destroy our farm communities across the north....So that I think, that was one of the seeds of demise.”

“And the computer system that they had for the venders to use. I know a lot of the venders were frustrated with it, it just couldn't change fast enough in order to incorporate everything and it got more and more difficult for use for customers as well. The OFN, the open food network, is something Jen was looking at bringing in, towards the end there, and it is way simpler system and it is working wonderfully. I mean, you get in there, you get set up, you can change your items, it, it just works so much smoother. So, I think, had that incorporated in, and we got some of the venders back in, because I went to a few of those meetings trying to, you know help it up at the end. And I think that would have helped a lot, the computer system was a real frustration for venders and customers.”

According to a CFLC newsletter, a new site upgrade occurred in 2017 to meet the growing on-line demands.

“I think the online order they had initially was easier than the second updated website which was harder to navigate. I would love to see the same great products they had before- especially meat and veggies.”

“....[] position essentially turned from a full time position, which it definitely needed to be full time position because dealing with all the different producers, and helping a lot of those elderly producers post their stuff on the website, and stuff like that, it definitely needed to be a full time position and when [] position turned from part time then to just like a couple of hours a week, that’s when we saw tons of products not being posted and just a lack of availability because unfortunately a lot of those producers are elderly or they don’t have, you know, the computer-type systems to be able to post those products and that’s a huge factor right there.”

Tipping Point #2 – Volunteers vs Staff

In the beginning, the CLFC hired both full-time and part-time staff to take on important roles for sustainability, thanks to various grants and funding. At one point, the CLFC boasted an administrative coordinator, as well as a coordinator for each of the hub sites, responsible for running the co-op’s day-to-day duties; an agricultural coordinator, who focused on helping farmers connect; and an education coordinator, who was responsible for supporting local food initiatives in classrooms and working with students in the greenhouse. CLFC also had a robust volunteer base that assisted with unloading and organizing products on pickup days, assist with administrative duties, assist with fundraising and finances, write grant applications, and help members without internet. The input of these individuals was considered an indispensable part of CLFC’s success.

At the time of the dissolution, volunteers were hard to come by and only one employee, working one half-day a week remained. These shrinking resources were not lost on the participants.

“...she had secured funding to have community coordinators, a paid position...Kenora/Red Lake.... Dryden/Sioux Lookout.... Emo/Fort Frances...Thunder Bay. They all died pretty quickly once we, the funding was over, just because people

couldn't volunteer. Kenora was already probably the most established, so I didn't mind staying on, it not being a paid position, I obviously just didn't have time to go to community events and do free, basically work."

"After my position stopped being funded and I wasn't being paid to travel there [Red Lake]I couldn't help her out any more in Red Lake and it kind of just withered off, so Red Lake died really quickly, which was really sad for the people that paid for memberships there, just because there was only so much we could do. Plus, with the delivery truck to.... from Lake of the Woods Brewing Company to Red Lake, only was able to go once month cause that's when they delivered beer. So, they weren't going to deliver for us, for free, more than once a month."

"I know I often sat that the travel information centre, with this food and phoning people to come and get this food....it was getting a little stressful as a volunteer, to be doing this, we had, I don't know, 150 people, and by the end it was only me doing the pick up and distribution.....sowell and I wasbeing a senior citizen I wasn't very keen on doing the winter pickups you know, because by then, it was already dark."

"It was hard to travel to Dryden and delivery to Sioux Lookout was not regularly scheduled. Raise the fees slightly and hire delivery workers?"

"I think part of the problem too, is that we got far too much into, in order to build volume, into all kinds of stuff that wasn't locally produced food. Maple syrup from Southwestern Ontario is not locally produced food, you know, and so that complicated it too. You know, handcrafts and all kinds of things are, you know, you got pages and pages and pages of stuff, and all you're looking for is some friggin hamburger, you know."

"At that time, it seemed like it was quite sustainable and ah, it just went from sustainable to unsustainable, really quickly. I didn't understand, I still don't understand."

"I thought that the focus on growth, the focus on getting another grant and building another thing and going to another town, and so on, was the wrong direction. But I sort of felt like we were watching, a, we were watching a rocket ship take off here, and you never know where it's going to go, but eventually it's probably going to explode. You know, and I guess that's what happened. I think there is still room for exactly what we were doing, but without ummm, the emphasis on the other communities."

Tipping Point #3 – The Business Model

CLFC described itself as being governed by a Board of Directors, which they reported as being elected annually by all members. The Board was responsible for approving new products, monitoring sales, removing members if necessary, and ensuring the overall smooth operation of the co-op. It also was responsible for input on the various events and programs that CLFC offered. Such undertakings highlight the importance of the Board role in this complex system and the need for such a Board to remain adaptive and responsive in order to maintain resilience and sustainability.

The prominent goal of the CLFC was to foster a thriving local food community through increasing farmer-consumer relationships; promoting naturally grown, fairly priced, healthy food; and, educating individuals on environmentally sensitive agriculture. This was the promise of membership, which cost only \$25 for a lifetime and allowed members to buy and sell foods through the online market. As a non-profit, the CLFC accessed grant monies and membership fees to cover capital expenditures, however participants who recognized issues related to the business model had provided the following feedback;

“We are direct to consumer farmers and were very concerned right from the beginning of the model adopted by the Co-op. We declined to participate. We told [those interested] that their model was too dependent of government support. The Clover Valley Farmer's market had a food box programme long before the co-op and knew that a minimum of 500 boxes per month sold at \$25 per box was the minimum number for any project such as this to be self-sufficient.

“I think there were so many opportunities to have been able to build relationships with different organizations and I think that really got missed in the first couple of years. Granted, it was just starting out so that's usually sometimes not the focus, it's just getting consumers and getting the products out there and stuff like that, but I think there's

potential for it to grow into such a larger thing in our communities with different organizations and stuff like that, and I don't know if that really got to happen at all."

"So, I think that relationships are key. And I do think that Cloverbelt didn't have, umm, didn't cultivate a lot of relationships with growers, they focussed on cultivating relationships with consumers, but maybe not as much as growers."

"I think the membership, I think should be altered, a little bit. Because it was a \$25 lifetime membership for consumers to be able to buy and then I think it was \$100 something for a producer for a lifetime membership. Kay, well, lifetime membership, isn't really much of a commitment at all. So, I think maybe if there was maybe, an annual membership, I think members maybe might take it a little bit more seriously, maybe there could be other perks, if we change the membership criteria."

"....and even the Farmers Market were sort of in direct competition with Cloverbelt as well.... because those same farmers would come bring their product to Sioux Lookout on a Farm day and if Cloverbelt was the Tuesday, people already have already bought their stuff"

"I have a lot of questions. I ask questions. Cause probably 18 months before the dissolution of the Co-op, I started to see some things...that were major red flags for me. About the way things were being run in the back office, who was handling what, who was taking care of things.... some producers weren't being paid on time, some producers weren't being paid at all. I personally didn't have issues surrounding that, but the fact that it was happening was.... huge.... I mean, that's a big barrier, if you're not being paid, you're going to pull your.....producer membership, and these were larger producers than myself, I mean, I was pretty small potatoes, right? So I could go a month, six weeks without being paid, it's not my income...it was more of a hobby for me, so I could do that and that wasn't a problem to me, but when I started asking questions...first of all, I was offered, I was offered a volunteer position that sounded an awful like a full time job position. I was kind of cornered and someone said 'you work at a bank.... well, we need...an accountant...we need, we have all of these, these...audits that need to be done and we are looking for someone to volunteer for as an accountant, would you be interested?' And I'm like, well, you know, how many hours are we talking about? In my mind I'm thinking hours, like a month? And they're like 'oh! Like you know, 10-15 hours a week?"

“The rules, I’m not sure if it’s national or Ontario, I think more national, actually.... the rules around auditing a corporation, put the auditor in a really bit of a straight jacket. The bottom line is, to audit a lemonade stand beside the street would cost \$10,000. So, when they do an unaudited financial statement, save that liability aspect of it, but it still, it does everything you need to do. Well, I don’t think we were aware of that neat little wrinkle that they use out west. And that was one of the big hang-ups, or one of the things that destroyed us in the end, was we could never find anyone to audit for us because for less than, like huge amounts of money. When you got, pick a number, \$40,000 worth of sales, you don’t really want to pay an accountant \$20,000 to look after the money. So that was a huge downer for us.”

“...I felt like I was a little bit blindsided...because I found that...I guess I’m talking about government regulations and government funding and stuff, when questions were asked to the Board and...prior, in months prior, everything was, you know, ‘we’re taking care of it, yeah, it’s challenging but don’t worry, we’re taking care of it, we’re taking care of it’. And then, you know, we get this email ‘we’re not taking care of it and we’re going to have to dissolve’. So that sort of, you know.... leads me on to what I saw as one of the biggest barriers and frustrations as a member-producer was the actual Board and you know, they way they were handling things.”

“...I was there in the end and so part of the problem was, you know, the employee that was hired, right, to do the finances.....and so I know part time work is, you know, it is hard to find people, I but I really think references need to be checked....if you are going to have an employee it needs to be a stand up employee....I do think that was part of the demise...it was just another nail in the coffin.”

“One of the.... barriers that was talked about, at that final meeting, I thought was also interesting, was just the how you formulate the membership of your co-op and how you.... who you allow in as producers, can change your regulations with Health Units, which can be a big barrier. So, if you’re largely selling...knitted baby caps and a couple people want to sell food, that can impact how they’re regulated versus if a large portion of your market is all food, and once you’re over 50 members it changes your regulation. So, there is a lot of foresight even to how you’re going to structure something, and it sounds like that also....started become a potential barrier going forward because they had so many members so that categorized them as needing such and such a regulation.”

“...things had lapsed so badly, that there was nobody even overseeing anything. Like, why wasn’t the Board stepping in six months prior, when producers were going to them saying ‘I haven’t been paid in three months, what’s going on? Why can’t you cut me a cheque?’ There were too many warning signs that were missed by the Board.... Like I

said, I was made aware of...this situation with the audits, some 18 months prior, maybe it was even longer...you know prior to the dissolution meeting....I questioned then, I was like what's going on guys?....And they were like 'oh, you know, if you don't want to do it, we'll find someone else.....' And I never heard anymore about it, until we got the dissolution."

In complex systems, like the CLFC, where there are a number of independent agents acting in unpredictable ways and whose actions are interconnected in the CLFC network, such that one agent's actions change the context for the other agents. Contexts can only change when the agents within that system begin changing their behaviour. According to the research (Stroink, et al, 2013) Complex Adaptive Systems (CAS), can learn from experience, if the system remains open to feedback and adaptability. These "feedback loops" (Stroink, et al, 2013, p. 37) provide opportunities for agents within the system to change and adapt in order to thrive and endure, bringing us to yet another would-be tipping point. Stroink, et al (2013) indicates this of feedback loops:

Feedback loops that are tighter, that return information to the system on the effects of its emergent outcomes more quickly, enable the system to be more responsive to its environment. Complex adaptive systems also exist across scales and are nested within one another. Each level can thus be both its own complex adaptive system and an individual element within a broader CAS. As a result of interactions across these scales, complex adaptive systems are both affected by and affect emergent properties at different scales. Such systems are constantly adapting and evolving. (p.37)

This dynamic would appear to resonate well with the first two phases of the adaptive cycle in complex systems, considered "the forward loop" according to Stroink, et al (2013), where, an organization, like the CLFC, grows

...by exploiting and organizing capital and increasing structure, connectedness and resilience (exploitation phase) to a point where (2) they consume all resources in simply conserving that structure while maximizing efficiency (conservation phase). At this point, the system's resilience declines as it becomes overly rigid and unable to adapt or respond to changing circumstances (p.4)

Tipping Point #4 – Leadership & Governance

The CLFC had adopted a cooperative governance model that allowed members to bring forward input and to vote on major changes to the operation of the enterprise. The idea was to support equal participation in the enterprise and help shape the direction moving forward.

“So, I think you know, we went in some wrong directions there and sadly, we didn't, we know, we ought to have done an audit, and started changing things a little sooner than we did maybe. Not an audit, a financial audit, but an appraisal of our operations and where we are going and so on.”

“I could see a need for start up funding, but I you know, I still can't wrap my head around how we couldn't continue to be at least somewhat partially self-sustaining. As a producer, I know it wasn't a huge percentage of my sales that went back to the Co-op, but it was, you know and I, so I was contributing to the, you know, the funding, and I had fellow producers who were contributing every week to the funding for the Co-op, and I couldn't see how, when we were doing well, sort of like, where did that money go? I was shocked when it was announced we no longer had the capability for a fulltime coordinator, because it was like, where is our money going? Like this space that we are using is donated, all of our...you are telling me that all of our assets have already been paid for with other funding, so why, you know, where's my thirty-five cents off that pumpkin I sold last week, where did it go?”

“I think it, had just grown too fast. It was too fast. It wasn't well enough established in the smaller area for a long enough period of time, you know, the honeymoon kind of waned off as it grew, and I think that was part of the problem.”

“When I first became a producer, you actually signed a...an agreement that you could have your kitchen inspected if you were going to sell baking and stuff like that and I fully expected somebody would show up and you know, call me or whatever and do that, and nobody ever did. And...maybe that was one, another one of the early warning signs that I missed at the time, but hindsight’s 20/20...that was something that was like, kind of out there, put out there and I remember asking about it....and that was like way back when we had, like, had a good coordinator...and she’s like ‘oh yeah, you know, we don’t actually have someone doing that right now, but if you’d like to have your kitchen inspected or something, we could arrange it.”

“...and that last summer that we were open in 2019, we just saw a lot of the producers fall off the wagon. We had quite a big, huge producers that became ill in Dryden, that couldn’t post anymore, we lost funding, so then we didn’t have stuff being consistently posted. There were barely any options for people to order, so people just stopped ordering and we went from 2018 summer, we consistently had between 20 to 30 orders every single week, and last summer in 2019, the most orders we had was like 5. Like consistently every single week. So just with the, you know, what was available to order, who was helping those farmers post the stuff, there was just a lot of factors there, unfortunately....and also lost our volunteer base, we couldn’t find any volunteers to help...when I had my paid position we did lots of outreach, and stuff and I did find that a lot of people still just didn’t know what Cloverbelt local food co-op was all about. Anytime I talked about it with somebody, they are like ‘I never even heard of that’ so I don’t really know if just right from the beginning when it started there wasn’t enough social media, there wasn’t outreach in the community from the beginning.”

“.... why do you haveYEARS of outstanding audits?’I was floored by that. I was like WHAT?....I mean if you, if you’ve applied for funding and your told within, you know, 18 months or 24 months, you need to roll back the, you know, the audit and submit that to the government you have to have it all your, you know i’s dotted and t’s crossed and send it in. Why, now is it four years later and that’s not been done...I don’t...If you have stepped into a role where you say ‘we’re going to accept this money on the condition that we’re going to take care of those things’ and then you just don’t do them? ‘Whose name signed those papers? Who said, that they would commit to making sure those audits were done and everything was done to accept that funding and then not do it?’ I wanted to hold that person responsible because I don’t even know who they are.”

“I never got to try it, by the time I was able to join it had been dissolved...I live an hour away from Ignace (At Sowden Lake), and I think I would have had to deliver my

goods to Dryden if I made sales as a vendor. That is about 2.5 hours of driving in each direction. So, delivering goods and spending 5 hours just for travelling wouldn't be worth it unless I knew I had enough orders to make up for the time and gas. This is what held me back from joining at first. (then the next year is when it dissolved) ALSO I had trouble understanding the website and how it worked. I wanted to purchase from vendors but didn't know where and when to do this. I think more simplicity was needed."

"We have the same situation here, in the Rainy River district, with the Future Development Corporation. Right? There is not a lot of umm ahhh, working relationship there, with businesses, like there should be, like there are in other jurisdictions. And part of it just the laziness of the bureaucrats in getting out and talking to people...that is what government has gotten away from. It is too bad, because I do think it's a relationship thing. Like, the AG Rep, or whatever you want to call them, I don't know what they're called now. Should be in the schools as you say, doing a sales pitch...and being a resource to the teachers, right? They should've been a resource to Cloverbelt."

The uniqueness of a governance model system tends to generate issues related to time and tensions "between elected officials and employees, and the governance overlaps and need for coordination between individual co-operatives, federal and provincial associations, federations, and international associations" (Johnson, 2019, p. 1).

Tipping Point #5 – Policies and Procedures

In the January 5, 2019 CLFC Newsletter, an announcement indicating that this would be the last week for the availability of eggs through the CLFC was made, contributing to would-be tipping point number five.

"The eggs, definitely, are when we saw the initial drop. And I guess that's the problem with the Cloverbelt too, so since all of it's surrounding with funding, there is very extreme health and safety kind of guidelines that have to be followed. So, what happened was, for the longest times, there was minimum requirements for people to be able to post eggs and chicken products. But then a new law came into place where they had to have this extreme, sort of like, stamp of approval, that their chicken and eggs

products were safe, and a lot of small farmers couldn't afford to get that stamp of approval. And that's when we saw a lot of stuff fall off, that the smaller farmers just couldn't afford to get that stamp of approval and for them to be on Cloverbelt, they had to pass those certain barriers to be able to post their products."

"...beyond the egg producer that we lost, like we lost several key meat producers and so that like, towards the end, those two things, when you don't have the eggs and meat, you just lose the traffic. And that's what I found, and we did talk a lot about that in the final meeting, but that was my experience from the last, you know, couple of months. I wasn't getting the orders, I was putting the same, you know, volumes of varieties out there that I had before, but I wasn't getting the orders, that I normally would on my, you know, through my business. I wasn't getting the traffic and I was finding I wasn't buying as much because there just, yeah. Once we lost those two big things, the eggs and the meat, it just, we, we lost a lot."

"A lot of the venders were frustrated with it and they dropped off. I was at a meeting where the venders came out, just prior to it closing, a couple months prior to it closing, and the venders were very frustrated that you know, there just wasn't the clientele anymore, umm they were traveling in from Emo and places like that to bring their product and they said it, it's not worth our while to bring that little of product with us."

"Find some egg & chicken farmers!!! I buy directly, but it was convenient to order those & pick up at 1 location."

Vulnerabilities – Skillsets, Regulations, Planning & Logistics

For four years, the CLFC enjoyed many successes in providing and distributing local food to NWO, while also improving the welfare of its communities and making considerable short-term profits for its members. With an adaptive mindset, the Co-op's ability to re-emerge is highly possible under the following conditions, according to Nelson, et al (2019).

In a food system [such as the CLFC], capital includes skills, knowledge, human energy, and economic wealth; stabilizing structures include legislation, policy, and physical infrastructure (Nelson & Stroink, 2014). With increasing stability, the system moves from exploitation (growth) to conservation. In conservation, the stabilizing structures provide efficiency but also undermine diversity and resilience as the system's energy and resources are consumed in maintaining the stabilizing structure and the system's ability to adapt quickly to the context declines. Release occurs when the system's structure collapses into a more chaotic state, often following a triggering event, and is followed by a phase of reorganization as agents from the collapsed system begin interacting in diverse new ways (Gunderson & Holling, 2002; Walker & Salt, 2006, (p.37)

As if to validate the phases of the adaptive cycles, the CLFC appears to have moved quite seamlessly into the release phase, which is also known as part of the "Backward Loop" (Stroink, et al, 2013). A release phase is often viewed as a disturbance to the system. If a disturbance pushes a system beyond its resilience capacity, the system breaks down. These disturbances can destroy structure and other forms of capital, whether it is natural capital, such as accumulated members, or social capital such as relationships and networks. If the resource base available to the system is not completely depleted by the disturbance, such as appears to be the case with the CLFC, a window of opportunity is created and may be what is necessary to set the stage for creating a new system configuration. Uncertainty and chaotic behavior create a foundation for examining vulnerabilities and reorganization, allowing the systems to begin the process of acquiring a new identity.

Vulnerabilities – Skillsets

“I probably had a little bit of an inside track, because I had been approached by a member of the Board....and then another person, who they had also approached said ‘no, no, no, don’t. You’ll kill yourself. I tried. And.... don’t do it.’ So that’s how I became aware.... it’s probably not something that a lot of people are privy to, but honestly, that to me, speaks to a Board not being transparent. Like really, if people don’t know that was the situation, and it only came up at the....dissolution meeting which is, it seemed like a lot of people were very shocked that these audits hadn’t been done, you know, that it was going to cost so much money to do these audits...they had sent out emails, you know, about the volunteer position, you know, for...somebody who is, who could....do some light accounting for them, is how it was worded..... It turned out that what they really needed was, actually, a forensic auditing accountant....to undo, undo years of absolute neglect, really.... like I said, who, who kept signing paperwork for funding that they had no intention of fulfilling the requirements for that funding. That bothers me. That is the thorn in my side.”

“Perhaps there ought to be a follow up meeting after some of the wrinkles were jumped over, soothed, talk about where we go from here, rather than take that as a dead end forever more.”

“...that’s huge...was the quality control. And also, just for people that were signing up to be producers as well, to consistently be posting. So, like obviously some of the producers were seasonal, the people that are posting vegetables aren’t going to be posting in the winter, that’s fine. But if you’re a meat producer, like, it would be consistent that that meat is available every single week. Because we had tones of people that would order from a producer, and then that producer just fell off the face of the earth and didn’t post for like four months later and it’s like okay, well like, if you’re going to be on the Cloverbelt, people get attached to your items, right? So there has to be some sort of commitment level that they’re going to be consistently posted. Obviously if they are seasonal producers, that’s fine, but then for that season, you’re going to commit to posting and maybe if you put, when you post your item ‘hey, this is a one-time item, we have a limited stock’, then the person knows. But I know a lot of our members in Kenora were disappointed with, you know, not being able to consistently get the items that they really liked. So, I think that would be a big thing too, if we were to revamp...the commitment from the producers posting.”

“The other piece that we are finding, is that a lot of people don’t know how to use products. Like, ummm, a lot of people don’t know how to grow brussels sprouts, which grow really well here, they don’t know how to cook them, ummm, some of the people don’t even know how to cut up a cauliflower, right? Cause they can buy it in pieces. Some people don’t ummm, the only thing they know how to cook sometimes, is ground beef and sausages. And

so part of that is an education process...it goes back to they cut out home economics so many years ago that people didn't learn about their food, they didn't learn anything, and now, you know, COVID has brought that all to light."

"...it was going to fall. That was.... absolutely....and I did not like how that was.... I mean, honestly, I'm upset with the woman, I'm upset that she was hired to start with, because.... I don't think that someone who wasn't bondable should've been hired. It was.... Knowledge in the community that this person was not a bondable person.... That person is not a bondable person is not somebody that you would hire for responsibility with money...and it came out afterwards, 'oh well, we weren't aware'. Again, I wanted to ask at the meeting, and I was shut down, but I wanted 'who hired her? Who hired her and why didn't they look at the credentials?' But, as I said, there were major problems before she was hired. She was only with the, you know, a few months.... Maybe it was six, but I don't even think it was that long."

"We have the same situation here, in the Rainy River district, with the Future Development Corporation. Right? There is not a lot of umm ah+hh, working relationship there, with businesses, like there should be, like there are in other jurisdictions. And part of it just the laziness of the bureaucrats in getting out and talking to people...that is what government has gotten away from. It is too bad, because I do think it's a relationship thing. Like, the AG Rep, or whatever you want to call them, I don't' know what they're called now. Should be in the schools as you say, doing a sales pitch...and being a resource to the teachers, right? They should've been a resource to Cloverbelt."

"So, there was an ordering period. So, ordering would open up Saturday at, I think it was like 1:00 p.m. or something like that and then it would close Monday at 9:00 a.m. and then that would be your order, so whatever is sitting in your basket, you would order. So for a lot of new members, even though we communicated that all over social media and stuff, we've always had tons of people, when they first put in an order, that wouldn't show up to pick it up, or stuff like that, because they didn't understand if something was in their basket that was their stuff to buy

"My opinion which is that the uh, the farmers co-op where we meet the customers face to face and chit chat about the weather and the cats and the dogs and whatever, is marketing. The online co-op is handling. Umm, you know, marketing is done it's just is the process. So, they complement each other, they're not in competition at all. But I don't' think.... the people that were intimately associated with the online co-op ever really bought that. They thought that the farmers market was hurting them, so that was one of the downers."

Vulnerabilities – Regulations

“Unfortunately, with our biggest egg producer...they had just upgraded everything, they had just invested all that money, they were slowly starting to see a return, and then BAM, the... Province came back and said ‘no, you’ve gotten too big now, and now you need to switch to this new equipment and you need to do this...’ and unfortunately they were having health issues in their family....and it was just a nightmare scenario that didn’t go well.”

“What happened with the chickens is that our abattoir closed down for renovations, so the chickens quit, and then the producer for eggs in the area didn’t renew his producing licence and he retired last year....that’s what happened with the eggs....he couldn’t afford it, it was over ten thousand dollars...and you can’t reuse the egg cartons, either, that’s another thing....every time....people would bring back the egg cartons he’d have to throw them away.”

“And the eggs are just so highly regulated, they are so over-regulated that nobody can enter the market

“I feel like you’ve been hearing like, Mr. X’s like story about that, like the red tape around that, is really, like it is going to scare people away from starting that up themselves. Because, you know, especially doing all those upgrades, and then to lose all that money and energy, put into that and then have the Province tell you ‘No, you need to redo everything and reapply and....’ Yeah, sometimes it feels like the Province doesn’t want small farms and they make it harder and harder.... I’m interested in selling eggs but going through the process of like being a graded egg thing, is kind of scary because of that.

“What I didn’t realize, what I think it was the \$5000 or maybe even \$10,000 licence that you have to have to transport your animal to the abattoir. So, if I had that licence and that truck, and Bev also had, you know she was just a small time maybe three animals, legally I couldn’t bring her animals to the abattoir. She would have to pay that license on her own...if we’re going to have to spend that, each of us, on a licence, we are in the hole even before we get the animal there....We tried to get that message to the government, at that time, they weren’t that interested in listening, now their ears are open a bit more because of the pandemic situation. You know, let’s strike while the iron’s hot and say; You know what? You are isolating us, you want us to do this, do this...Work with the farmers here! Like stop making them broke before they even get to market....If we can send a letter to the federal and provincial governments and just say.....and I know years ago, the feeling I got, was they wanted all the farming done in southern Ontario, so they just regulated the Northern Ontario

farmers to death. But now all those farmers are turning into parking lots, because...they, you know, 'Oh we're not producing corn anymore because.... of the growth. So now they're like 'oh maybe the people in the North..... "

"Its so tough that farming has been so regulated, cause I think, you know, like you said, you have to choose one or the other, you can't do both, it's so sad that we don't have, you know, in this area, we don't have the ability to produce enough to do both....everything is so highly regulated it's extremely difficult."

"...and even often government regulation can change to help one producer, but not the other, as example, meat/bird farming, so first they had, anyone, as long as it's sort of meat produced at an abattoir could sell it. But the problem was, you'd have to have a quota, to be a viable farm, so producers were struggling, and then the market wasn't there, so they said let's have.... What's the right term? artisanal chicken numbers would say, 5000 birds...but then as part of that legislation now, if you're under, if you don't have an artisanal licence now you can't sell meat, even if it is produced as part of an abattoir.....and I get why they do it, but now you've hurt even the smaller farmer.....anytime you make changes you're hurting someone else."

Vulnerabilities – Planning & Logistics

"Most co-ops have a limited life..... Volunteer associations generally, like even lodges and so on, they age, just like people age.... it's not unusual for this co-op to have, you know, hit a wall...and that's not the fault of these people.... who else is going to do it? It's the same as our...fellow that did the computer work for us. He just did it, I think, as a community service thing and he thought 'great thing to do, kind of fun, then he was stuck with it forever more."

"...the capacity is there to do more...but as I said, how do you get it to the customer? Often the customer wants to be able to get it the easiest way possible, in other words at the store or, if it's on line, it comes to my house, right, all those easy ways."

"We dedicate so many days per week for growing and baking and Friday is my delivery date to Ignace only and I want to expand into other places. Like last year, I went to outdoor markets, I went to Dryden, on Thursdays, and then I went to Sioux Lookout on every other Friday, to their Farmers Market and then every Saturday in Ignace. And then, I was trying to pick up other places, too. It's just hard, right? That's a lot, it's a lot of time, in a lot of.... Every market is a preparation time ahead of time, to package up

orders and get everything ready. I still got to make the stuff and grow it, so, yeah. If there was some sort of the delivery system, I can go to Ignace but going farther than that, that's just, it ends up taking up my day and stuff. Because I was thinking, if there was some sort of a, like a hub spot, in Ignace, where people could bring their orders to on a specific day, and then it's brought to, whichever city wherever their orders ended up at, that would be good."

"...unfortunate timing. The local butcher.... they had to shut down, they were doing a major refurbishment of everything, so even though, like a co-op stepped into...got organized to take that over and buy that, and it's up and running now. Unfortunately, the timing was, that they were completely shut down over the winter when we lost two other meat producers who were using them for packaging as well. So, it was.... when you only have one local butcher, with, you know, that's doing local meat, within what? A 300 km radius, it was a huge blow....there are two other family run butchers, but they were only doing their own. But the other one, also, that did some egg productions, they.... they just told me no.... We aren't doing it anymore; the licensing is a hassle and we're not."

"....and sadly, we had a few people that joined right before it closed that never even got to make an order, so. That was unfortunate. So, I definitely got to see the difference between having paid positions, or people that can really dedicate the time to finding new products, finding new providers, and also just promoting the food co-op."

"I was always interested but never found the prices to be within my budget... I would suggest that there not be a membership fee for those that were just trying it out. Membership should be for those using it all the time, and maybe those memberships will lead to something exclusive."

".... It got to be towards the end, it got to be almost only craft stuff on there, no fresh produce, no fresh meats, right..... because drop in sales. You know, right, drop in sales, like I said, they, they didn't want to travel to bring the product in, because it wasn't worth their while, there just wasn't the sales there that there used to be.....I know that when I went to pick up my order towards the end there, we used to have up to 80 tubs. Like 80 different orders. Sometimes even more for people to come and pick up. And towards the end there, we were lucky if we had 20 orders....it was just diminishing itself."

One thing that remains consistent in complex systems, is that change is difficult (Holling, 2020) and “It often means stopping doing something that we have done for years” (p.1). Holling goes on to say:

But the adaptive cycle tells us that unless we release the resources of time, energy, money and skill locked up in our routines and our institutions on a regular basis, it is hard to create anything new or to look at things from a different perspective. Without these new perspectives, and the continuous infusion of novelty and innovation in our lives, our organizations and our systems, there is a slow but definite loss of resilience, and an increase in rigidity.” (Holling, 2020, p.1)

This study has allowed us to examine CLFC and explore new perspectives in order to identify opportunities for the re-emergence of a viable local food production, processing, and distribution in NWO.

“We invented the wheel once, we got a flat tire, now, there’s a secondary thing going on. So again, if they’re willing to join, or if we can just add on to that, or whatever, like to me, like she said, when your setting it up it’s a lot of work, once you got it in place, it can run relatively smooth. So again, let’s not reinvent the wheel, if those, the group that’s up now, is willing to work, you know, with the past one, let’s do that. I just think the more collaboration we can do, the better off we’re going to be.” (Sonja, 1:00:03)

As the CLFC system processes the dynamics of several triggering events, leading up to the dissolution of the organization, attempts are happening to return the system to an equilibrium state. While the processes of reorganization and innovation phases are recognized, they are considered to be a means to regain the status-quo; not an end in itself. Understanding the overall dynamics of the CLFC is important. “It is important to learn to work with rather than fight against these cyclical patterns of creative innovation, consolidation, ossification and eventual dissolution to make room for

transformative innovation and renewed creativity” (Wahl, 2016). In an attempt to work with these patterns, our three sample groups have identified many dynamic opportunities for adaptation supporting the re-emergence of the CLFC.

Opportunities for Adaptation

Recognizing that the CLFC can never return to the exact structure, functionality and processes as before the dissolution, participants were asked to re-imagine a new local food co-op and explore what that might look like. This ability to reframe and work on new visions of the system is consistent with complex adaptive theory, where a regeneration and reorganization of the system occurs following the release stage, providing fertile grounds for experimentation and innovation. A common property of many complex systems is resilience, that is, the ability of the system to react to collapses, internal failures, and environmental events by absorbing the disturbance and/or reorganizing to maintain its functions.

Participants in the project were able to identify many collaborative opportunities, both old and new.

“I am a member of Harvest Kenora, we encourage community resiliency through local food production. We are also looking at how we can bring more regional food into the community and are talking with Fireweed Food Co-op in Winnipeg about potentially becoming a customer.”

“... so that the delivery handling processes has to be simplified and maybe delivery directly to the consumer on way, or maybe there’s a better way. I assume the Fair Board would still be willing to cooperate with us, allowing us use of their building, you know. But ahh, I don’t know, that that process needs to be simplified and, in the event, from the consumer side, it needs to be made much easier to go in and order something.”

“...One of the discussions that should be had at the start, with especially the big producers, like NW Beef and even the abattoirs and the producers is; do you want to have the retail market type scenario, or do you want to have a Cloverbelt, or a co-

operative or an online type model? And the reason I say that is, I sort of seebecause of what happened to Cloverbelt, I could see, say NW beef gets up and going and they start having large production and then a Walmart, or a Sobeys says 'yeah, I'll take all your beef' and then they go to the store and then that's gone from a local producer. The farmers are happy and that's great for the economy.....but you kind of have to go one or the other.....if you try to do both....the volume isn't, like I'm talking about the local store here, they are talking about getting local beef, will the price point work, but, I'm not sure...saying hypothetically it does, well then I'm not going to be able to buy it, you're not going to be able to buy it, because the farmers are going to sell it directly to the store. So that is something that all the producers need to have that same vision.....The reason I think I think it should stay a cooperative model is, as soon as you get into retail, you have the huge mark ups required and of course their sale dollars are going to be lower, because they have to sell wholesale pricesit takes money out of the system. That is the real question."

"The Open Food Network is worldwideso you have input from farmers from everywhere, agriculture everywhere, right? So. Yeah, and it incorporates craft people and everything too, right? It works for everyone, just like the Co-op did here. You could go in, but it's so much easier to use, so much easier. I actually went on and used it as a vender, just to find out how it works and that, ummm for one of our venders that doesn't have computer at home. I been doing their stuff and it works so much better."

"It would be a small store with only local foods from NW Ontario, ideally just the Rainy River District. It would have hours that are convenient for shoppers and producers, and the staff running it would be knowledgeable about the source of each and every product. It would include First Nations producers as well. May get a bit sticky in having preserved veggies and fruits but I am sure that could be overcome. Recently a page was started on Facebook for RR District food producers in an attempt to allay food security fears due to Covid. A person must produce/gather food within the RRD boundaries to be able to post on the page and so far, it seems to be going quite well. Spring is here and crops are being planted, meat animals are being utilized and awareness is being raised within the district that yes you can buy a lot of food produced locally. A number of producers have sold out already and the page has only been up a month. We admins feel this page is just the tip of the iceberg of what CAN be done. Future plans include possible classes on methods of food preservation as well as harvesting of vegetable, fruit and meat sources."

"One program that's just started that I think will be very successful is the Northern Harvest program and it's a funding program through the federal government to basically give communities or Indigenous groups, dollars to be able to harvest local food.....there has been a lot of uptake already, I think that'll be very successful. I think that would be a good segway into that local production...Sioux Lookout Area Aboriginal Management Board, they're the agency that got the contract to distribute these funds."

“I was on a ZOOM meeting with Erin O’Toole, who is running for the Conservative Party and I know that the Conservative Party is now looking at incentives for the far north and I’ve talked to a few candidates federally and provincially, that are looking of ways to bring things to the far north

“The way I hold my online market might be great - each vendor posts their own products to the Facebook page then they arrange their own deliveries and transactions. It’s all free and we take care of ourselves. Just like this new Open Food Network, I love this new thing.”

“Manitoba people are much more co-op orientated, like the culture out there is much more ‘let’s help each other’. Ontario is much more ‘we smart government people will look after you dumb ordinary people’ Here in NWO are much more Manitoba orientated.”

In addition to collaborations, many thoughts on a revised service delivery approach evolved. Thoughts ranged from creating a standardized subscription box, to integrating into existing storefronts, to developing a delivery service and supporting greenhouse growers.

“If you could re-imagine – “Pre-orders for pickup coincide with the farmers market. Not sure if it’s doable though. Similar facility like Kenora. Permanent tent with hydro at the park by the arena. Pre order pickup at a certain area and the rest is just market sales.”

“We made sure that when we did the math, we put in \$18.00 worth of food in a \$25.00 box, because the intent at the end of the day, was that the five, six, seven dollars would go towards paying help, transportation, overhead of the packing place.”

“It was hard to travel to Dryden and delivery to Sioux Lookout was not regularly scheduled. Raise the fees slightly and hire delivery workers?”

“So, I would just caution you that these food box models, there needs to be a decision made at the front. Is it going to be a subsidized cheap food box for low income

people, which I'm not against, I think that there's a place for that, or is it going to be a box that supports farmers in a way that is reasonable?"

31:03 "Coming here, I think, I think it's just being able to learn what resources are out there. I find it extremely difficult in Fort Frances to find out what is here, you know, like it seems like everything is well hidden, or they don't advertise, or you know, like everything is done the old school way, like so you read the newspaper and find things out, nothings on line, you can't, you know like do certain things. So, I think it's just for me, coming from a place that was a little more up to date, it's just learning what are my options and you know making those things public."

"I still used the co-op during the summer even though I was at the Farmers Market everyday or every Farmers Market.... because I wanted to keep it going! I wanted it to be around. People have to realize that ok, you go out once a week, or twice a week, to the Farmers Market but in the winter time, your weekly supply of your meats and things is, is on line and we don't have enough greenhouse growers, so the fresh produce and everything, falls off during the winter months, so that too, could've been a draw back.....More greenhouse farmers that go through the winter months would be better."

"I would prefer an end of the week pick up, so I have the groceries for the weekend prep. I think the online order they had initially was easier than the second updated website which was harder to navigate. I would love to see the same great products they had before- especially meat and veggies."

"Consistency from producer to producer, I heard some issues with. So for example, you'd have one farm, one meat farm that would do really well with vacuum sealing and making sure everything was in tip top shape, and then you'd have another producer who maybe went to the bottom of the deep freeze and had meat packaged and it was freezer burnt and that type of thing and it wasn't coming in consistently bad, but when we have new, new towns coming in, and if that was their first order, and they got a piece of freezer burnt meat from the bottom of the chest freezer, I'm sure that they weren't coming back. So, even though, you know, it reflects badly on individual producers, it also reflects badly on the co-op as a whole. So, I think it might've been a little bit better to have stricter quality control."

".... affordability. I personally, I do like to support local as much as possible, I do realize that when you are not a massive company it is more expensive to produce your product, whatever it happens to be, but I have found that the market is a little pricey,

especially for those that are in need, for food. So, to reach a greater community base, I wonder if there would be, something like a senior's day, or something like that, where you can involve more of the community because I do find that most of the people that go to the market, are people that have the money to go the market. Where as I always used to think of markets as 'oh what a great place to go to get local, to get fresh, to get inexpensive' and now I find it more expensive. But I still try to support it as much as I can, because I want to support my community but for others it will be a barrier."

"...might be an industry right there in doing all this delivery.... if that could happen, I bet you would get a whole bunch of Sioux Lookout people back into the groove for the co-op."

"That's I think, where the co-op, a co-op could fill that role as well, by being that one source, because I mean, I deal with a lot with these producers and processors and things, and it's difficult for me even, because there is so many."

"We were taking the information to our schools, our public schools, and it's amazing, like even, Dryden is a small town, but kids didn't know where their food was coming from, like they thought it was coming frozen in a box from Safeway's, or Walmart or whatever.....to me, the important part of it was to pass that knowledge down....so we don't lose it. I know now with this pandemic, people are turning their front yards into gardens.... if we're not self-sufficient we can be in big trouble...it's desperate times now, we need that, we need this more than ever."

"Something that I was exploring too, it seems as though there's a market for commercial kitchens. So with all of this, if restaurant dining isn't going to be as big as it was before, you know, you could have kitchens and restaurant sort of doing things a little bit differently, where they rent out their space to producers, to, you know, make a huge batch for the week or the day, of things, so that they, if they can keep a food handler present there, and follow all the regulations and be able to get their product to market without having to invest in the kitchen themselves, or you know, just making that readily available for people who are looking to get into the food game, cause there are a lot of youth that, you know, want to, want to jump in but there is just so many restrictions and barriers that they don't ever end up penetrating that. So, if there is a commercial kitchen in the region that might be something helpful."

"Social media, especially to capture, you know, the younger generation. I think just, you know, the logo, the way it was kind of presented on social media, I think,

could've, it could've done a little bit of a better job and I get it cause it's a non-for-profit, they only have so much time to work on social media and stuff like that, but to engage a proper following. Everybody is on social media now, right? So, to capture people and get the word out there, that's like what needs to be done is to have like, a little bit more of a stronger marketing plan for the year. I think a lot of the stuff was kind of shared on the whim. I would share stuff when I could, and I definitely, that was a part of my job when it was paid, was a part of it, was social media, but I know that the other community coordinators, it definitely was the last thing, priority wise, for them. Just because it wasn't in their comfort level or wheelhouse. So, I think finding funding for a proper marketing and social media person to revamp a website to focus on social media, I think, I think that's a huge point."

Participants provided a range of insights that ranged from the modest, such as keeping things simpler, to recruiting a new Board, to the more challenging where membership agreements were overhauled.

"A new board. I would have liked to see the option to vote in a new volunteer board. That option was not discussed at the dissolution meeting, just the fact the old board was stepping down. New volunteer board, with understanding that audit/compliance requirements be met MONTHLY and YEARLY. Funding in place to hire a full-time qualified co-ordinator at 35+ hrs per week, at a living wage salary (minimum \$35,000 yearly salary) Honestly, I think it might be my dream job"

"To me the meeting was cut short. What I wanted to...ask was that if there was anyone in the room who would be interested in replacing the Board. I was willing at that time to put my name forward.... we got to the point of almost discussing that and then a person that doesn't even live in our community that moved away years ago, piped up and said 'oh no! The rules of order say that if you've had a call to get to the vote, and while we must get to the vote about whether we are dissolving this or not, there is no more time for discussion."

"I think the membership, I think should be altered, a little bit. Because it was a \$25 lifetime membership for consumers to be able to buy and then I think it was \$100 something for a producer for a lifetime membership. Kay, well, lifetime membership, isn't really much of a commitment at all. So, I think maybe if there was maybe, an annual

membership, I think members maybe might take it a little bit more seriously, maybe there could be other perks, if we change the membership criteria.”

“I was always interested but never found the prices to be within my budget... I would suggest that there not be a membership fee for those that were just trying it out. Membership should be for those using it all the time, and maybe those memberships will lead to something exclusive.”

“....and sadly, we had a few people that joined right before it closed that never even got to make an order, so. That was unfortunate. So, I definitely got to see the difference between having paid positions, or people that can really dedicate the time to finding new products, finding new providers, and also just promoting the food co-op.”

“People got too darn busy, to, times are tough, these last 10 years, as far as I’m concerned. People got too busy trying to make ends meet, and do what they had to do, to spend time going to the Farmers Market, and people, and even maybe got too busy to go and pick up their stuff.... But you know, I think, it ought to have worked in favour of the co-op, like ‘hey, here is a way you can, you can do your, get your local food without it taking the extra time and so on’. I think it should’ve worked for us, but maybe it worked against us too, just that extra complication and then that, my own personal opinion, the new system just kind of done us in.... I believe, that the customers.... fell off more than the vender base, you know. Of course, if you’re a vender and you’ve got to drive 20 miles to town and all you got to sell is 10 pounds of potatoes, the gross amount you’re going to get from the potatoes won’t cover the gas of driving to town. You’re only going to do it, if there’s a big enough customer base to make it worthwhile, so they both kind of faded away together.”

“...maybe trying to streamline a better membership process for producers and even for consumers, would be great. I know there was like, I think we had over close to 200 members in Kenora, but I would only see the same, like, thirty people every single week. So, people bought memberships and then never ordered. So, I don’t if that’s like they just forgot about it or they went in and out of phases where they were ordering but...”

“I was a member....probably several months after it started.... I was able to see how it changed over time....at the beginning when it seemed to be really thriving, there was a pretty solid volunteer base. So, the expectation was, if you were a member of Cloverbelt, you had an obligation to do some work toward it. So, there was a, people

would be signed up, to work shifts to receive the order and then distribute it and wait there for pick up. When it was thriving, there was a lot of variety.... “

“Participation would depend on the capacity of expectation. Buying....yes, volunteering...not sure (I have in the past) selling goods...possibly, the market would need to include home based businesses as well. If it's too much to do P/U and farmers market at the same time you could have the home-based businesses and P/U one day of the week and farmer's market another week day. Possibly have 3 market days, just ideas”

“This is my vision and I hope together we can all make this happen! On Saturday after market, all producers gather excess that they are not interested in bringing home. They sell that to me at a discounted price and I work to ensure that bounty is sold and/or preserved for sale to lengthen our season. This is where I need kitchen/storage access but am scouting locations--Possibly we could work out a deal with the agricultural center and have each producer commit to one day per summer for kitchen help/knowledge transfer? I could find another area for cold storage if need be although having kitchen and storage together is ideal. Along with that program, I would love to give a platform to producers to sell their personal product lines through my pickup and delivery system.”

REFERENCES

- Holling, C.S. (2020). Resilience and adaptability. *Social Innovation Generation*. Retrieved from <http://www.sigeneration.ca/home/resilience-and-adaptability/>
- Nelson, C.H., Stroink, M., Levkoe, C.Z., Kakagemic, R., McKay, E., Stolz, W., and Streutker, A., 2019. Understanding social economy through a complexity lens in Northwestern Ontario: Four case studies. *Canadian Food Studies / La Revue canadienne des études sur l'alimentation*. 6 (3),33–59.
- Stroink, M.L. & Nelson, C.H. (2013). Complexity and food hubs: Five case studies from Northern Ontario. *Local Environment: International Journal of Justice and Sustainability*. 18(5), 620-635.
- Streuker, A., Levkoe, C. and Nelson, C. 2017. The Cloverbelt Local Food Co-op: A Case Study. Centre for Sustainable Food Systems, Wilfrid Laurier University. <http://nourishingontario.ca/the-cloverbelt-local-food-co-op/>
- Stroink, M., Nelson, C.H. & Davis, A (2013). Supporting growth and innovation in local food initiatives through crowdfunding and crowdsourcing: Two case studies in northern Ontario. In *Nourishing Communities*, A. Blay-Palmer, I. Knezevic, C. Levkoe, P. Mount and E. Nelson (Eds.). Toronto: University of Toronto Press.
- Thompson, P. (2019). Top co-op issues 2019. Centre for the Study of Co-Operatives, University of Saskatchewan. Retrieved from <https://words.usask.ca/thinkingaboutcoops/2019/02/22/top-co-op-issues-2019/>
- Wahl, D.C. (2016). The adaptive cycle as a dynamic map for resilience thinking. [*Designing Regenerative Cultures*]. Triarchy Pres.Ltd. Dorcas: UK.

APPENDICES

Appendix A – CLFC Dissolution Post



Dear CLFC Members,

We are writing to advise you about the status of the Cloverbelt Local Food Co-op (CLFC).

It is with great sadness that we must announce that at the September 10th, 2019 special member meeting it was decided to proceed with dissolution.

At our June 4th, 2019 member meeting, our directors brought forward concerns about declining engagement, which began in the fall of 2018. Although we hoped it was a temporary trend, the decline rapidly increased in severity. Producers became frustrated with declining orders, and some elected to stop posting inventory “until things turned around”. In turn, consumers had less product to shop for, and became even less interested. New regulations brought forth from OMAFRA and the Northwestern Health Unit posed additional hardships for producers, and as a result, the only egg grading station in the Kenora District elected to close. The loss of fresh farm eggs was of great detriment to the market as a whole. As discussed at both meetings, new website changes in 2018 brought about unanticipated challenges which also contributed to this decline. Many consumers simply state a lack of convenience as their ultimate reason for neglecting to order regularly.

After a May board meeting, the board reflected on the ideas brought forth from the membership to increase engagement and reviewed a cash flow forecast. It was decided to decrease the administrative coordinators hours to reflect the current order volume and revenue. The board tried to augment marketing efforts on a volunteer basis. One director took over social media, and another was compiling the weekly newsletters. Although we ideally operate with 7 board members, we have had only 5 directors serving for quite some time, which limits our capacity. In addition to these measures to reduce our expenses, a partnership had been established with Open Food Network, a new online platform, which our webmaster has been investigating for over a year. We hoped to be able to change online ordering platforms to help boost engagement but had to a) be sure the platform would better serve our purposes now and in the long term and b) make some modifications to allow it to serve our needs. We were just now at a point that we could consider making a switch.

Along the years, maintaining adequate financial records for our legally required audits has been an ongoing challenge, due to persistent staff turnover and limited expertise. These audits carry a cost of \$8,000-\$10,000 per year and our auditor is currently struggling to complete 2016's audit.

Pilot Research Project on Cloverbelt Local Food Co-op

This picture limited our ability to continue to pursue funding support. Several attempts have been made over the years to improve this situation. In September, a sudden employment decision forced us to terminate order cycles abruptly. We did not have adequate resources to attract, train, engage and oversee a staff member who could continue operations adequately and catch up neglected financial records over the last few months. An additional crisis arose which required immediate and urgent attention and is still being investigated for resolution. Furthermore, our current debt load now significantly exceeds cash on hand.

On September 10, 2019, the Co-op held a Special Membership Meeting at the Dryden District Agricultural Centre, with online participation enabled for members throughout the region. A nearly unanimous decision was made to dissolve Cloverbelt Local Food Co-op and divest its assets based on the challenges outlined above. This was a very difficult decision for all who have been closely involved with this organization.

Although this decision is disheartening and unexpected, we thank our members for their unwavering support and understanding. CLFC has accomplished many wonderful achievements since its inception in 2013. We believe it carried out its mandate to make local food more visible and accessible, through many innovative avenues. In addition to the online market which drew 1600 members throughout the region, and serviced up to nine Northwestern Ontario communities, we operated a school education program, supported more healthy food in classrooms, constructed and operated a community greenhouse, held numerous workshops, hosted fun community events such as the restaurant competition “LocaWars” and the farm to fork event “Honey Love”, created an online map of regional producers, constructed a draft regional food charter (after many community consultations), which highlights the vision of local food for our region, and many other wonderful initiatives. We also created jobs, invested money in many local businesses through the above ventures, and supported expanded markets for our regional farmers. Thank you to all of our partners, volunteers, supporters, producers, and directors who contributed to these great successes along the way.

The CLFC Board is currently working with Brenda Bell to guide the disposal of our remaining assets in accordance with the law.

Kind regards,
The CLFC Board of Directors
cloverbeltlocalfoodcoop@gmail.com

Appendix B – Survey Post & Invite

Cloverbelt Survey

Understanding CLOVERBELT LOCAL FOOD CO-OP - Moving Forward



Dear Community Member & Research Participant;

You are invited to participate in a research project titled Understanding the dynamics of CLFC Food Co-op through a complex adaptive systems perspective through Lakehead University. This research is funded through a SSHRC Partnership Grant FLEDGE (Food: Locally Embedded, Globally Engaged). We are offering you the opportunity to participate in this research that will provide Northwestern Ontario with community perspectives on factors that contributed to the dissolution of CLFC (Cloverbelt Local Food Co-op) and community perspectives on the future of local food production, processing and distribution in Northwestern Ontario. We invite you to share your experiential knowledge about what has been learned about how to produce, process and distribute food in Northwestern Ontario.

We are inviting you to participate in a ZOOM community focus group or alternatively to arrange for a personal interview by phone, Zoom or in person when feasible. The focus group will last approximately 90 minutes or alternatively a personal interview of approximately 60 minutes.

This research is important to discover how we in Northwestern Ontario see our place in local food production, processing and distribution. What role do we want to have in a local food system that can sustain access for consumption of local food?

Pilot Research Project on Cloverbelt Local Food Co-op

The results of this research will be available to you through your local municipal or township office. The results of this study may be distributed in academic journals, conference presentations and in other publications.

If you want any additional information about this research, please contact:
Connie Nelson, Lakehead University (807) 627-1721 cnelson@lakeheadu.ca or
Kim Ducharme, Lakehead University (807) 631-2479 kaduchar@lakeheadu.ca .

We thank you in advance for sharing your perspectives on factors that impacted the dissolution of CLFC and your thoughts on the future of local food production, processing and distribution in Northwestern Ontario.

- 1. How important is access to local food sources to you and your family?**
 - Very important
 - Moderately important
 - Not so much.
 - I'm not as familiar with local food sources as I would like to be.
- 2. Tell us about your relationship with CLOVERBELT LOCAL FOOD CO-OP.**
- 3. What do you miss most about CLOVERBELT LOCAL FOOD CO-OP?**
- 4. From your experience, what was the biggest barrier to regularly using CLOVERBELT LOCAL FOOD CO-OP?**
- 5. From your experience, what were the strengths of the CLOVERBELT LOCAL FOOD CO-OP?**
- 6. If you could have suggested an improvement to CLOVERBELT LOCAL FOOD CO-OP, what would it be?**
- 7. If you could re-imagine a NEW local food co-op, what would it look like?**
- 8. Do you have any other comments or helpful information to share?**
- 9. We want to hear from you. If you are interested in discussing further, please provide your contact information below.**

Appendix C – Zoom Focus Group Invite



FACEBOOK EVENT



MAY 25 AT 10 AM – MAY 29 AT 11 AM UTC-05

Understanding Cloverbelt Food Co-Op

Online Event

Calling all CLFC and NWO community members!

You are invited to participate in a research project titled Understanding the dynamics of CLFC Food Co-op through a complex adaptive systems perspective through Lakehead University.

This research is funded through a SSHRC Partnership Grant FLEDGE (Food: Locally Embedded, Globally Engaged).

As spring is upon us, sadness is creeping in about the loss of our beloved food co-op. We have had many (former) members reach out in hopes of the birth of a new food co-op. This project is a first step in that direction. We invite you to share your experiential knowledge about what has been learned about how to produce, process and distribute food in Northwestern Ontario.

We will be hosting a series of consultations via ZOOM as well as the option of personal phone interviews as requested. The list of suggested dates for the community ZOOM groups are provided below. Each ZOOM focus group will last approximately 90 minutes or alternatively a personal interview of approximately 60 minutes. You are welcome to participate in both the community ZOOM group and also ask for some individual time to share your perspectives. PLEASE REGISTER!! WE NEED YOUR INPUT!

Your participation is voluntary, and you have the right to withdraw at any time. We will be audio-recording your information so as to ensure accuracy. Individual participants will not be identified in published results without their explicit consent. The results of this research will be made available to you through your local municipal or township.

If you want any additional information about this research, please contact:

Connie Nelson, Lakehead University (807) 627-1721 cnelson@lakeheadu.ca or

Pilot Research Project on Cloverbelt Local Food Co-op

Kim Ducharme, Lakehead University (807) 631-2479 kaduchar@lakeheadu.ca .

We thank you in advance for sharing your perspectives on factors that impacted the dissolution of CLFC and your thoughts on the future of local food production, processing and distribution in Northwestern Ontario. After registering for one of the ZOOM events below, you will receive a confirmation email containing information about joining the meeting. PLEASE FEEL FREE TO SIGN UP FOR ANY ONE OF THESE EVENTS!

RED LAKE - Time: May 25, 2020 10:00 AM Eastern Time

Register in advance for this meeting:

<https://lakeheadu.zoom.us/meeting/register/tJErf-yhrj8oG9JrOXaToMpr4MIHdNvKP3ZR>

DRYDEN - Time: May 25, 2020 02:00 PM Eastern Time

Register in advance for this meeting:

<https://lakeheadu.zoom.us/meeting/register/tJUrc-2hrDsoH9SJKZokWrUfOun4SV6BnjUs>

SIOUX LOOKOUT - Time: May 26, 2020 10:00 AM Eastern Time

Register in advance for this meeting:

https://lakeheadu.zoom.us/meeting/register/tJ0scu6grT4iGtJ7cL5SBiEUHFxjw93BUm_F

FORT FRANCES/EMO/RAINY RIVER

Time: May 26, 2020 2:00 AM Eastern Time

Register in advance for this meeting:

<https://lakeheadu.zoom.us/meeting/register/tJwtfu2hpi0sGNMmDhoC5OSSzgYl111z0HjV>

KENORA - Time: May 27, 2020 10:00 AM Eastern Time

Register in advance for this meeting:

<https://lakeheadu.zoom.us/meeting/register/tJUpcOitpzliGNMgnzbotBTxfhuO2jdhnk6B>

IGNACE/UPSULA - Time: May 27, 2020 02:00 PM Eastern Time

Register in advance for this meeting:

Pilot Research Project on Cloverbelt Local Food Co-op

<https://lakeheadu.zoom.us/meeting/register/tJcpf-qpriggH9StNzvrGrO4z37cUUrPZR6v>

OPEN/NON-SPECIFIC - Time: May 27, 2020 06:00 PM Eastern Time

Register in advance for this meeting:

<https://lakeheadu.zoom.us/meeting/register/tJAkf-6rqzloEtAy7c-asq4w1VdnBkUGldnI>

Appendix D – Participant Consent Form



Name of Participant _____

(please print)

- I have discussed the details of this research project and agree to participate in the research.
- I understand that my participation in this study will bring minimal risks or harm.
- I understand that my participation in this study is voluntary and that I may withdraw at any time for any reason without penalty.
- I understand that there is no obligation to answer any questions that I feel uncomfortable answering.
- I understand that information I provide will never be attributed to myself individually unless I agree but may be attributed to my community in generic terms.
- I understand I may ask questions of the researcher at any point during the research process.
- I understand that the results of this study may be distributed in academic journals, conference presentations and in other publications and that a summary of the results is available to participants.

I give permission for this interview to be recorded and for parts of it to be shared publicly (please circle one):

Yes

No

I agree to be identified in this research (please circle one): YES NO

I am fully aware of the nature and extent of my participation in this project as stated above.

Participant's Signature

Date

If you have any questions or concerns about this study, please contact Connie Nelson, School of Social Work, Lakehead University (807)345-8529. If you have questions about your rights as a research participant in general, please contact Sue Wright at the Research Ethics Board at 807-343-8283 or research@lakeheadu.ca.